OSHA Fixed and Portable Ladder Checklist (29 CFR 1910.23)

Use before a ladder's first use each shift and on routine site walks.

OSHA 29 CFR 1910.23

DATE	SHIFT
INSPECTOR	AREA / EQUIPMENT ID

Before you start

1. Mark every item OK, Defect or N/A.
2. If a ladder has a structural or other defect, tag it "Dangerous: Do Not Use" (or similar wording) and keep it out of service until it is repaired or replaced (1910.23(b)(10)). If a use or setup item fails, correct it before the ladder is used.
3. Fall protection for employees on fixed ladders is set by 29 CFR 1910.28 and 1910.29 and is not covered by this list.

Legal basis: 29 CFR 1910.23: Ladders (Part 1910 Subpart D, Walking-Working Surfaces) Fall protection for fixed ladders: 29 CFR 1910.28 (duty) and 1910.29 (system criteria) Source: eCFR, Title 29 (text as of 2026-11-09)

Online version and sources: https://safetyindex.blog/us/standards/1910-23-ladders

SECTION A | All ladders: condition, spacing and tagging

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
1	Rungs level and evenly spaced Ref. 1910.23(b)(1)	With the ladder in position for use, every rung, step and cleat sits parallel and level, with even gaps.	☐	☐	☐	
2	Rung spacing Ref. 1910.23(b)(2)	Centerline gap between rungs measures 10 to 14 in. Elevator-shaft and telecom-tower ladders follow (b)(2)(i) and (b)(2)(ii).	☐	☐	☐	
3	Rung clear width Ref. 1910.23(b)(4)	Portable ladders 11.5 in or wider. Fixed ladders 16 in or wider (this figure applies before a ladder safety system is fitted).	☐	☐	☐	
4	Wooden ladder finish Ref. 1910.23(b)(5)	No paint or other coating that could hide cracks or other structural defects.	☐	☐	☐	
5	Metal ladder corrosion Ref. 1910.23(b)(6)	Made of corrosion-resistant metal or has a protective finish against rust.	☐	☐	☐	
6	Sharp edges and burrs Ref. 1910.23(b)(7)	No surface that could puncture or lacerate the climber.	☐	☐	☐	
7	Shift inspection done Ref. 1910.23(b)(9)	Ladder checked for visible defects before its first use this shift, and again whenever conditions call for it.	☐	☐	☐	
8	Defective ladders tagged Ref. 1910.23(b)(10)	Any ladder with a defect carries a "Dangerous: Do Not Use" (or similar) tag and stays out of service until repaired or replaced.	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION B | Climbing and portable ladder use

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
9	Right ladder for the job Ref. 1910.23(b)(8)	Ladder used only as its design intends, with no improvised uses.	☐	☐	☐	
10	Facing the ladder Ref. 1910.23(b)(11)	Workers face the rungs going up and coming down.	☐	☐	☐	

General guidance only, not legal advice. Check the current regulation and your employer's procedures.

SECTION B | Climbing and portable ladder use

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
11	Hand hold Ref. 1910.23(b)(12)	At least one hand on the ladder throughout the climb.	☐	☐	☐	
12	Loads carried Ref. 1910.23(b)(13)	No one climbs carrying an object or load that could throw them off balance.	☐	☐	☐	
13	Load Ref. 1910.23(c)(3)	Total load (weight and force) of the worker and all tools, equipment and materials carried is within the ladder's maximum intended load.	☐	☐	☐	
14	No moving with a worker on it Ref. 1910.23(c)(6)	Nobody is on the ladder when it is moved, shifted or extended.	☐	☐	☐	
15	Stepladder top Ref. 1910.23(c)(8)	No one standing on the cap or top step.	☐	☐	☐	
16	Ladders joined for length Ref. 1910.23(c)(12)	Ladders or sections are not tied or fastened together for extra length unless specifically designed for that use.	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION C | Portable ladder equipment and setup

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
17	Metal rung surface Ref. 1910.23(c)(1)	Rungs and steps are corrugated, knurled, dimpled, skid-coated or otherwise treated against slipping.	☐	☐	☐	
18	Stepladder spreader Ref. 1910.23(c)(2)	Metal spreader or locking device holds front and back sections securely open during use.	☐	☐	☐	
19	Single rail ladders Ref. 1910.23(c)(5)	No portable single rail ladder in use.	☐	☐	☐	
20	Footing Ref. 1910.23(c)(4)	Feet on a stable, level surface, or the ladder is secured or stabilized against displacement.	☐	☐	☐	
21	Traffic areas Ref. 1910.23(c)(7)	In a passageway, doorway or driveway, the ladder is secured or barricaded off, for example with cones or caution tape.	☐	☐	☐	
22	Slippery surfaces Ref. 1910.23(c)(9)	A ladder used on a slippery surface is both secured and stabilized.	☐	☐	☐	
23	Top support Ref. 1910.23(c)(10)	Both side rails bear at the top of a non-self-supporting ladder, unless it has a single support attachment.	☐	☐	☐	
24	Extension above landing Ref. 1910.23(c)(11)	Side rails reach 3 ft (0.9 m) or more above the upper landing surface being accessed.	☐	☐	☐	
25	Base Ref. 1910.23(c)(13)	Not stood on boxes, barrels or other unstable bases to gain height.	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION D | Fixed ladders

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
26	Clearance behind rungs Ref. 1910.23(d)(2)	7 in (18 cm) or more from the rung or grab bar centerline to the closest fixed object behind. Elevator pit ladders need 4.5 in (11 cm).	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION D | Fixed ladders						
No.	**Check item**	**What to look for**	**OK**	**Defect**	**N/A**	**Notes**
27	Grab bar projection Ref. 1910.23(d)(3)	Grab bars do not stick out past the rungs on the climbing side.	☐	☐	☐	
28	Side rail extension Ref. 1910.23(d)(4)	Through or side-step ladder rails rise 42 in (1.1 m) or more over the landing or access level. For parapets, see (d)(4)(i) and (d)(4)(ii).	☐	☐	☐	
29	Through-ladder extension Ref. 1910.23(d)(5)	No rungs in the extension. Rails flared to 24–30 in of clearance, or no more than 36 in with a ladder safety system.	☐	☐	☐	
30	Grab bar height Ref. 1910.23(d)(7)	Grab bars stand 42 in (1.1 m) higher than the landing they serve.	☐	☐	☐	
31	Hatch Ref. 1910.23(d)(9)	Hatch cover opens with enough clearance for easy access to or from the ladder. Counterbalanced covers open to 70 degrees or more from horizontal.	☐	☐	☐	
32	Individual-rung ladders Ref. 1910.23(d)(10)	Rungs built so feet cannot slide off the ends.	☐	☐	☐	
33	Step-across distance Ref. 1910.23(d)(12)	Through ladders: 7–12 in to the structure edge. Side-step ladders: 15–20 in to the platform access points.	☐	☐	☐	
34	Side clearance (no cage or well) Ref. 1910.23(d)(13)(i)	15 in (38 cm) clear on each side of the centerline.	☐	☐	☐	
35	Climbing-side clearance (no cage or well) Ref. 1910.23(d)(13)(ii)	30 in (76 cm) clear on the climbing side, or 24 in (61 cm) at an unavoidable obstruction fitted with deflector plates.	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION E | Mobile ladder stands and platforms						
No.	**Check item**	**What to look for**	**OK**	**Defect**	**N/A**	**Notes**
36	Step width Ref. 1910.23(e)(1)(i)	Steps 16 in (41 cm) wide or wider.	☐	☐	☐	
37	Slip-resistant steps Ref. 1910.23(e)(1)(ii)	Steps and platform have a slip-resistant surface, built in or added (dimpling, knurling, coating, tape).	☐	☐	☐	
38	Handrails (top step 4 ft or higher) Ref. 1910.23(e)(1)(v)	Handrails 29.5–37 in (75–94 cm) high from the step's front edge, or chains or gates in special-use applications.	☐	☐	☐	
39	Height-to-base ratio Ref. 1910.23(e)(1)(vi)	Work surface no higher than four times the shortest base dimension, unless outriggers, counterweights or similar stabilizers are fitted.	☐	☐	☐	
40	Movement-impeding system Ref. 1910.23(e)(1)(vii)	Units on wheels or casters have a system to impede horizontal movement while someone is on the unit.	☐	☐	☐	
41	No movement when occupied Ref. 1910.23(e)(1)(viii)	Unit stays put while anyone is on it.	☐	☐	☐	
42	Top step guarding over 10 ft Ref. 1910.23(e)(2)(ii)	Handrail 36 in (91 cm) or higher on three sides. Midrail and toeboard where the top step is 20 in or more front to back.	☐	☐	☐	

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SECTION E | Mobile ladder stands and platforms

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
43	Platform guarding 4 to 10 ft Ref. 1910.23(e)(3)(ii)	Handrails 36 in (91 cm) or higher plus midrails in the platform area, or chains or gates in special-use applications.	☐	☐	☐	
44	Platform guarding over 10 ft Ref. 1910.23(e)(3)(iii)	Guardrails and toeboards on every exposed side and end.	☐	☐	☐	

DEFECTS FOUND AND ACTION TAKEN

Item no.	Defect description	Reported to	Action taken / date closed

SIGN-OFF

SAFE TO OPERATE? ☐ Yes ☐ No: tagged out of service	
INSPECTOR SIGNATURE	DATE / TIME
SUPERVISOR REVIEW	DATE / TIME